

CORE FORMULA

What? -> So What? -> Now What? -> What? = what actually happened, plainly and without interpretation. -> So What? = why it matters, what it means, what changed. -> Now What? = the next small, concrete step. -> Minimum viable move: What happened? Why does it matter? What is the next small step? -> Field rule: use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Silently sort what you want to say into what happened, why it matters, and the next step — then say those three things in plain language, without naming the framework.

BEST FOR

- Debriefs and after-action reviews
- Supervision and coaching conversations
- Learning reviews and reflective practice
- Journalling and thinking on paper
- Project retrospectives
- Turning a messy experience into a clear next step
- Making a meeting contribution concise and memorable

PHRASE BANK

Framing openers · Quick openers

- "Here's what happened, here's why it matters, here's the next step."
- "Quick version: what, so what, now what."
- "Let me keep this to three things."
- "So — what happened, then what it means, then what we do."
- "I'll be brief: fact, meaning, next step."
- "Give me thirty seconds to lay this out."
- "Short version first, then we adjust."

Reflecting with someone · Warm, unhurried

- "Want to talk it through? What happened, what it meant, what's next."
- "Let's start with just what happened — no need to solve it yet."
- "That sounds like a lot. Shall we work out what it means before the next step?"
- "Take your time on the "so what" — that's the part that matters."
- "No rush on the "now what". We can sit with the meaning first."
- "What stood out to you about it?"
- "What do you make of it, and what feels like the next move?"

Meetings and updates · Work, concise

- "Here's the situation, here's why it's significant, here's what I'd propose."
- "In short: what we saw, what it tells us, what we do next."
- "The finding is X; the implication is Y; the recommendation is Z."
- "Let me give you the headline, the meaning, then the ask."
- "Three parts: what happened, the impact, the next step."
- "I'll keep the background short and spend the time on what it means."
- "Bottom line, then the reasoning, then the decision we need."

Naming the next step · The "Now What?" move

- "So the next small step is?"
- "Given all that, here's what I'd do first."
- "What's the one thing that changes because of this?"
- "The meaning is clear — now what do we actually do?"
- "Let's turn that into a single next step."
- "What would you like to happen next?"
- "One concrete action from this: ?"

Checking and simplifying · Course-correct

- "Let me check whether that structure is useful, or if we should approach it another way."
- "I can keep this short and then we can adjust it."
- "The main point is X; the rest is only support."
- "Tell me if I've jumped ahead — I want the meaning right before the next step."
- "Which part landed, and which should we drop?"
- "Let me back up to what actually happened."
- "Is this the right frame, or would something simpler help more?"

Feedback and hard conversations · One step at a time

- "Here's what I noticed. Here's why it concerns me. Here's what I'd like to change."
- "Can I lay out what happened, then what it means to me, then a way forward?"
- "One thing at a time — first the facts, then how it landed."
- "I want to be clear, not to corner you: what happened, what it meant, what next."
- "Before we fix anything, can we agree on what actually happened?"
- "Let's name the impact before we jump to solutions."

Written and text · Scannable, digital

- "What happened: ? Why it matters: ? Next step: ?"
- "Three quick lines: fact, meaning, action."
- "TL;DR up top, then the detail if you want it."
- "Labelling this so it's easy to scan: What / So what / Now what."
- "Short one: here's the what, the so-what, and the next step."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses What? So What? Now What? as a visible script and sounds rehearsed.
Better: Uses the framework silently to organise a concise response.
Best: Uses it flexibly, then checks whether the listener is clearer, more heard, or better able to respond.
2. Weak: Jumps straight to "Now What?" before the meaning is understood.
Better: Slows down on "So What?" so the next step actually follows from the meaning.
Best: Lets the meaning lead, so the next step feels obvious rather than imposed.
3. Weak: Announces the framework by name and narrates each step.
Better: Keeps the labels in your head and speaks in plain sentences.
Best: Sounds like a clear-thinking person, not someone running a template.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version — one line per step, or just the headline and the next step.
"Quick version: what happened, why it matters, what's next."

If The listener is emotional or needs support

Validate first and delay the framework until they feel heard.
"Before we structure it — that sounds hard. Do you want to talk it through first?"

If The listener needs a story or example

Switch to an example-led neighbour such as STAR or CARL.

"Let me give you a concrete example of how it played out."

If The listener needs to act

Move quickly to a single clean "Now What?" and stop there.

"So the one next step is?"

If The listener looks confused or resistant

Summarise and invite correction rather than pushing the structure harder.

"Let me check I've got this right — tell me what I'm missing."

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Make your contribution concise and memorable — one line per step. — "Here's what we found, here's why it matters, here's what I'd suggest we do."

Written update or email

Put each step in a short labelled paragraph or bullet so the reader can scan it. — "What happened: ? Why it matters: ? Next step: ?"

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback would help first, then use the structure lightly. — "Can I share what I noticed, what I made of it, and one idea for next time?"

Difficult conversation

Use one sentence per step, then pause and let them respond. — "Here's what happened. Here's why it lands for me. Can we talk about what's next?"

Debrief or retrospective

Walk the group through the three moves so reflection turns into an action. — "Let's do what happened, then what it means, then what we change."

Personal journalling

Write the three headings and answer each honestly — it turns venting into a decision. — "What happened / So what / Now what."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Someone is overwhelmed and needs to be heard first
- The moment calls for validation before analysis
- The person cannot safely act yet
- There is distress, shame, grief or anger in the room
- A power imbalance makes structure feel like control
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Sort one experience

Take one thing that happened today and write it under three headings: What happened, So what, Now what. Keep each to a sentence.

Day 2 — Write a 60-second version

Turn a recent situation into a 60-second spoken response using What? So What? Now What?, said out loud.

Day 3 — Cut it by a third

Take yesterday's response and cut it by a third without losing the core point.

Day 4 — Drop the labels

Say the same response again in plain speech, without naming any of the three steps.

Day 5 — Slow the So What

Practise a case where you deliberately linger on "So What?" before offering any "Now What?".

Day 6 — Use it live once

In a real meeting or conversation, run the structure silently and end with one clean next step.

Day 7 — Practise a recovery

Rehearse one recovery line for when the structure lands badly, then reflect: did clarity actually improve when you used it this week?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use the framework to serve the listener, not to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear?
- Did I keep it concise?
- Did I let the meaning settle before jumping to the next step?
- Did I adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve their autonomy and dignity?